



Proposal: Fine Arts Credit for Pipe Organ Encounter Participants

Submitted to: Committee on Pipe Organ Encounters (CoPOE), American Guild of Organists

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1. Executive Summary

Optio proposes to award 0.5 fine arts credit (a semester-equivalent music course) to teen participants of the 2026 Pipe Organ Encounters who document their learning at the camp. The credit posts to the student's transcript with a grade of A. Optio is a WASC-accredited education provider, so the credit is real, transcript-bearing, and generally accepted for transfer to virtually any U.S. public or private high school. For homeschool and unenrolled students, Optio issues an official accredited transcript record.

For summer 2026 this is offered at no cost to the AGO, host chapters, participants, or families, across all four POEs. Participation is opt-in for each student and family. The work happens entirely during the POE week itself, inside Optio's app, and requires

minimal administrative effort from organizers: an Optio-specific announcement email sent by the AGO to all attendees, a short onboarding window on day one of camp, and a single point of contact. If schedules align, Tanner is willing to attend the first day of each of the four POEs in person to lead the onboarding and answer questions.

We request the committee's endorsement to offer this as a 2026 pilot under a lightweight letter of agreement, with the shared intention to review results together and, if successful, formalize a renewable national framework for future years. Optio will charge for the program in future years to make it sustainable; the cost model is presented here as options for the committee to weigh together with Optio rather than as fixed terms.

2. About Optio

Optio is an education company that helps high school students earn official, accredited high school credit for serious, hands-on learning experiences and passion projects. Students document their work on Optio's online platform, Optio assesses that work against academic standards and issues credit, which is then transferred to the student's school of record, or provided as a standalone accredited transcript record for homeschool and unenrolled students.

Optio's program is accredited by WASC (Western Association of Schools and Colleges). Because WASC is one of the recognized regional accreditors, credit issued through Optio is accepted for transfer by public high schools nationwide on the same basis as credit from any other accredited institution.

Optio exists to recognize learning that happens outside the traditional classroom. A Pipe Organ Encounter, an intensive, mentor-rich, performance-based immersion in a demanding art form, is exactly the kind of learning the platform was built to credential. This proposal is offered in the spirit of supporting the AGO's mission and the pipeline of young organists, beginning with the Utah Valley POE that Tanner's home chapter is hosting this year.

3. The Offer

What students receive	0.5 fine arts credit, equivalent to one semester of a high school music course, posted with a grade of A
Who is eligible	Teen POE participants who opt in
Where it applies in 2026	All four POEs scheduled for summer 2026
Cost in 2026	Free to AGO, host chapters, participants, and families
What students must do	Document their POE learning inside the Optio app during the week of camp
Effort required of organizers	The AGO sends an Optio-specific announcement email to all attendees; the host site provides a short onboarding window on day one and a single point of contact

4. Why a POE Justifies a Semester Fine Arts Credit

Optio's WASC-accredited model awards credit on demonstrated mastery of academic standards. Credit is granted when a student produces evidence of

competency in the relevant domains, here the National Core Arts Standards for Music (Create, Perform, Respond, Connect): music performance, musicianship and theory, music history and literature, and reflective and creative practice.

A POE develops all four areas at a high intensity. Across the week, students work through private organ lessons, group instruction, theory, organ history and literature, improvisation and hymn playing, masterclasses, supervised practice, instrument field trips, and recital attendance and performance. Documented inside Optio, this body of work is sufficient to demonstrate the competencies the credit certifies. We assess against the standards, not against time spent, which is precisely the strength of an accredited competency-based model.

5. The Student Experience

How the opportunity reaches families

The AGO sends an Optio-specific email to every 2026 POE attendee explaining the partnership and the opportunity. Optio drafts the email, the AGO sends it from its existing channels. No new mailing infrastructure is required of host chapters.

Interested students and families follow a link in that email to a dedicated Optio enrollment page for their POE, where they review what is involved and complete a brief enrollment with parental consent. Enrollment is free and entirely optional, and declining has no effect on POE participation.

Optio will also host a video chat information meeting prior to the start of the POEs to answer questions and explain the process to interested families.

Onboarding at camp

On day one of each POE, Optio provides a short (about 15 to 20 minute) onboarding for opted-in participants. Students learn what to track and how. If schedules allow, Tanner will attend the first day of each of the four 2026 POEs in person to lead this onboarding, meet families, and answer questions live. Where in-person attendance is not possible, Optio provides a self-guided video and a one-page handout the site distributes.

What students do during the week

Each day at camp, students log their learning in the Optio app: lessons and what was worked on, practice, masterclass and class notes, repertoire progress, performances, and short reflections. Photos, audio, and video can be attached as evidence. The experience is designed to be lightweight, run on a phone, and stay out of the way of the camp itself. All of the work required for the credit happens during the POE week.

Bringing family along: Optio's Observer feature

Each student can invite parents, siblings, grandparents, friends, mentors, and other supporters as observers on their Optio account. Observers see the student's documented learning as it happens (practice notes, masterclass takeaways, repertoire progress, photos, audio, and reflections), without needing to be at the POE. For families whose teen has traveled out of state for the camp, this turns the POE into something the whole family experiences with the student, and it gives extended family and mentors who couldn't travel a real window into a week that often

becomes a formative experience. It also gives parents direct visibility into the academic substance that earns the credit.

Receiving the credit

After camp, Optio reviews each student's documented learning against the standards and issues 0.5 fine arts credit, recorded on the transcript with a grade of A. Students and families receive a clear record of the credit and instructions for transfer. Optio communicates directly with families throughout, so POE staff are not the support channel.

6. How the Process Works Administratively

Optio is responsible for the enrollment system and parental consent, the tracking platform, student onboarding materials, ongoing student support, standards-based assessment, credit issuance, transcript records, and transfer to each student's school. Optio is the accredited academic provider and bears the accreditation, transcript, and data-handling responsibility.

The AGO and host POE sites carry a small, well-defined lift:

1. The AGO sends one Optio-specific announcement email to all 2026 POE attendees (Optio provides the copy).
2. Each host site provides a short onboarding window on day one of camp (a roughly 15 to 20 minute slot, or distribution of a self-guided video and handout if Tanner cannot attend in person).
3. Each host site designates one staff point of contact for logistics coordination with Optio.

Indicative 2026 timeline (per POE):

Timing	Activity	Owner
About 4 weeks before camp	Optio supplies the email copy, enrollment link, and FAQ	Optio to AGO
Pre-camp	AGO sends the Optio-specific announcement email to all attendees	AGO
Pre-camp	Interested families enroll and provide parental consent	Families, Optio
Day 1 of camp	15 to 20 minute onboarding (in person by Tanner if possible, otherwise self-guided)	Optio
During camp	Daily learning logs and evidence inside the Optio app	Students
Within a few weeks after camp	Standards-based review, credit issuance with grade of A, transfer to school of record	Optio

Student data and privacy for minors: as an accredited education provider, Optio handles student information consistent with FERPA-aligned practices. Enrollment requires explicit parental consent, collects only what is needed to issue and transfer credit, and is opt-in. The AGO and host chapters are not custodians of student data under this model.

7. Credit Transfer and Homeschool Students

Each student receives 0.5 fine arts credit recorded on the transcript with a grade of A. For enrolled public and private school students, Optio works with the student and family to transfer the credit to the student's school of record. Because Optio is

WASC-accredited, receiving schools evaluate the transfer on the same basis as any accredited transfer credit. Optio handles the paperwork and follows up.

For homeschool and unenrolled students, Optio issues an official accredited transcript record families can use for their homeschool records and college admissions. Given the committee's observation of a growing homeschool presence at POEs, this is a meaningful benefit for that population specifically. Many homeschool families actively seek accredited, transcriptable records of advanced study, and a POE is an exceptional one.

8. Summer 2026 Pilot Scope

The pilot covers all four 2026 POEs. It is free to all parties and opt-in per student and family. All required student work is completed inside the Optio app during the POE week itself. Optio absorbs all platform, assessment, accreditation, and transfer costs for the pilot. A short post-pilot review (participation, completion, credit-transfer outcomes, and organizer and family feedback) will be shared with the committee to inform future-year decisions.

9. Approach in Future Years

We would like to grow this thoughtfully and in partnership with the committee rather than presenting fixed terms. Optio will charge for the program in future years to make it sustainable at scale. After the 2026 pilot review, we propose evaluating the following models together:

- Option A: optional family-paid. Participation remains opt-in and free of cost to the AGO. Participating families pay a per-student fee, with AGO endorsement.
- Option B: AGO and chapter-supported. Students and families never pay. The AGO and/or host chapters cover a modest annual national partnership fee, a per-student fee, or a combination, so the program is free at the point of participation.
- Option C: blended and sponsored. A combination of the above, potentially with scholarship or sponsor support so the opportunity stays accessible to families with need.

Optio's preference is a model that keeps the cost burden on individual families as low as possible, ideally with AGO or chapter partnership and scholarship support layered in. We are glad to model costs at expected POE volumes to support the committee's deliberation.

10. Partnership and Agreement Structure

For 2026 we recommend a lightweight pilot letter of agreement that:

- Authorizes Optio to offer the credit opportunity at the four 2026 POEs.
- Confirms it is free in 2026, opt-in, and requires parental consent.
- States that Optio is the accredited provider and is solely responsible for academic, transcript, data-privacy, and transfer obligations.
- Limits the AGO's and chapters' role to endorsing the opportunity and sending the announcement email.
- Includes a post-pilot review.

If the pilot is successful, we would welcome negotiating a renewable national framework agreement for subsequent years, incorporating whichever future-year model the committee selects from Section 10. We are not asking the committee to commit to a multi-year contract now, only to endorse the 2026 pilot and the intent to formalize later if it works well.

11. Next Steps

1. Discuss at the CoPOE meeting on May 29, 2026.
2. Tanner is glad to join a video call with the committee, before or after the meeting, to walk through the platform and answer questions live.
3. On the committee's endorsement, Optio will provide a draft 2026 pilot letter of agreement, the announcement email copy for the AGO to send, and the onboarding materials for each POE. Tanner will plan, schedule permitting, to attend day one of each of the four 2026 POEs in person.